Egypt: Ethiopia claims deepen Cairo's role in Sudan

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【メール原文】

Alleged Ethiopian involvement will likely draw Egypt deeper into Sudan’s civil war. Early in November, the Egypt-backed Transitional Sovereignty Counc||||||||||||||||

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Alleged Ethiopian escalation will deepen Cairo’s involvement in Sudan

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Alleged Ethiopian involvement will likely draw Egypt deeper into Sudan’s civil war to bolster the Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) against the Rapid Support Forces (RSF).
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Mutual interests will preserve Cairo’s ties with Abu Dhabi even though the two back opposing sides in Sudan.
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Cairo will continue to step up its military presence in the Horn of Africa to pressure Ethiopia as bilateral tensions mount, but it is unlikely to directly attack Ethiopian territories or the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD).

Alleged Ethiopian involvement will likely draw Egypt deeper into Sudan’s civil war. Early in November, the Egypt-backed Transitional Sovereignty Council of Sudan (TSC) filed a complaint against Ethiopia at the UN Security Council, accusing Addis Ababa of facilitating RSF drone attacks from Ethiopian territory against Sudan. The TSC also accused Ethiopia of hosting military camps that train thousands of RSF troops, and the UAE of financing the RSF and Ethiopia’s military support for the group.

Cairo has said it is ready to activate its mutual defense agreement with Sudan following Khartoum’s accusations of Ethiopian interference. Allegations of greater Ethiopian involvement in Sudan’s civil war will likely push Egypt to scale up its military support to the SAF and preserve the balance on the ground. The RSF has already been accusing Egypt of attacking its forces since 2024, which Cairo has repeatedly denied.

Cairo will likely focus on supplying arms, deploying air defense assets, and providing limited air support. This would fit with the conservative approach to regional involvement it adopted in Libya’s civil war and in its recent support for Saudi Arabia’s defense against Houthi attacks. Supporting the SAF would not involve deploying troops to Sudan, as Egypt wants to avoid casualties and the risk of a broader war.

Deeper involvement in Sudan carries little risk to Egypt's domestic security. The RSF has limited offensive capabilities that could seriously threaten Egyptian territories. It has threatened to attack any airport from which strikes against it are launched, but its reach would likely be limited to Egypt's southernmost military bases. Egypt's involvement in the Saudi-Houthi war carries higher risks by comparison, given the offensive capabilities of the Houthis, Iraqi militias, and Iran (see: Defending Saudi Arabia preserves geopolitical alignment and financial ties , 20 October 2026).

Cairo's ties with Abu Dhabi will endure despite opposing alignment in Sudan. Cairo views Abu Dhabi's ties to the RSF and backing for Ethiopia as a threat to its national security interests. Nonetheless, mutual benefits continue to preserve bilateral relations amid these tensions, as they have since the war in Sudan began. The UAE has been Egypt's largest source of FDI since 2024, totalling more than $43 billion, and Cairo is eager to preserve these inflows. The UAE, for its part, values opportunities in Egypt's domestic market and strategic ports. It also would not want to anchor ties with the Arab world's most populous country (and its largest military) to Sudan's civil war.

Mounting Egypt-Ethiopia tensions will fall short of direct confrontation. Ethiopia's alleged escalation against the SAF would deepen tensions between Cairo and Addis Ababa, already strained by Ethiopia's unilateral management of the GERD and its efforts to gain access to the Red Sea through Eritrea or Somali breakaway regions.

Cairo will continue to bolster its military presence in the Horn of Africa to pressure Ethiopia, including the gradual deployment of 10,000 troops and military assets to Somalia to support stability and counterterrorism efforts, and increased military cooperation with Eritrea (see: Low risk of military clash amid Egypt-Ethiopia GERD dispute , 9 September 2025). Addis Ababa also accuses Egypt, Eritrea, and the SAF of arming and supporting Ethiopian insurgent groups in their civil conflict against the federal government (see: War likely to remain largely contained within Ethiopia's borders , 15 October 2026).

Still, Cairo is unlikely to directly attack Ethiopian territories, including the alleged camps where RSF troops train or the airbases from which drones allegedly strike Sudan. Cairo is also unlikely to attack the GERD despite the ongoing disputes over the dam. Egypt wants to avoid a broader conflict with Ethiopia that might trigger regional or international backlash, sanctions, or capital flight. Damage to the GERD also risks flooding large areas of Sudan, and possibly southern Egypt as well, so it remains an unlikely target.

Hussein Suleiman
Senior Analyst, Middle East & North Africa
suleiman.ne@eurasiagroup.net
EG Middle East & North Africa
mena@eurasiagroup.net

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